



Telling stories

In fact, the story of movie arguably stretches back to prehistoric times, to human ancestors hunched around a fire as one among them used the light to cast shadows on the wall and illustrate tales of fearsome beasts or unlikely heroism. When the audience settle into their seats for an insanely expensive, effects-fueled blockbuster on a towering IMAX screen, they're back around that fire. Movie in the 21st century is still a telling of stories with words and images, bringing those images to believable life.

This book is an attempt to build a narrative of movie history out of the movies themselves, taking a tour of a hundred or so movies from Méliès on through the next century and beyond. Each entry discusses where a movie came from, maps its inspiration and how it was made, documents the men and women whose talent shaped it, and details the ripples of influence it sent out.

It is a story that crosses time. In the silent age, the first men and women explored the possibilities

of moving pictures. From there, the story slips into the 1930s and 1940s, the gilded years when cinemas stood on every main street and movies were beloved slabs of mass appeal; the age of movie stars such as Humphrey Bogart, Katharine Hepburn, and James Stewart. In the 1950s, filmmakers from Europe, India, and Japan created a string of masterpieces that still receive acclaim to this day; this was the time of Henri-Georges Clouzot, Akira Kurosawa, Yasujiro Ozu, Nicholas Ray, and Satyajit Ray. A new generation took hold in the 1960s and 1970s, and broke the established molds. And then the story of cinema arrives in the present, where movies are made with technology that would have been the stuff of science fiction even 10 years ago, whole worlds spun into being at the push of a button.

Blissful immersion

The beauty of movies is that every individual has a different way of looking at them, and a different route into loving them. As a writer

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Each picture has some sort of rhythm, which only the director can give it.

Fritz Lang

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and movie journalist, this book's consultant has spent much of his adult life in cinemas seeking out movies that can give him that feeling of blissful immersion he was hooked on as a child: “I sit while the lights dim and I'm the seven-year-old who yelped with laughter at Harpo Marx on a rigged-up screen at a friend's birthday party; or who escaped a family Christmas at 10 to switch on the old TV set upstairs, and found that *Citizen Kane* was playing; or whose mind was comprehensively blown at 14 by the dark, unnerving movies of David Lynch. Those moments live on every time I see a film.”

A couple of decades after *A Trip to the Moon*, with a luckless Méliès soon to find himself selling »

“I live now in a world of ghosts, a prisoner in my dreams.”

Antonius Block / The Seventh Seal